

Instagram, and that's how people knew I was doing it. When I'd talk to a friend, they'd ask me how it was going, and one friend in particular who'd asked me out to lunch saw I was doing a no-spend challenge and, without my asking, suggested we do something else. I also wanted to get a coffee when I was with another friend, but she'd asked me about my challenge, so I felt like I couldn't buy something in front of her! My daily posting was meant to encourage others to stick with their no-spend challenges, but it had the unexpected benefit of helping me stick with mine.

Finally, tracking actions can help you see your habit change in a tangible way. Tracking helps you stay focused on your goal, provides rapid reinforcement of positive behaviors, and increases awareness of behaviors and patterns. If you're not tracking, you don't know if the actions you're taking are getting you to where you need to be. Many people try to track progress, but progress can be a disappointing and an uncontrollable thing to track. We love to see those cute grids and big thermometers fully colored in when someone pays off their debt, but if that's all you focus on, the months or seasons you color less, or can't color at all, may do more harm than good to your motivation. Tracking actions is much more gratifying than tracking progress. Unlike progress, you have total control of the actions you take and don't take, making it much more motivating to track. And it helps you take responsibility for your improvement as much as your mistakes (because we're far more likely to dwell on our mistakes than celebrate our success). You can also track them daily, maybe multiple times a day, so they're top of mind more often than a once or twice-a-month debt payment or savings transfer. Here are some examples of actions you can track:

- Days you skipped takeout coffee

- Meals you didn't get takeout for

- Days you didn't make an unplanned grocery store trip

- Days you ate dinner at home

The list goes on. But just because the list can be long doesn't mean your list should be. Intentional focus means honing in, so choose three to four actions that have the greatest impact on *your* spending. Your 90-day transaction inventory can help you get started determining what these actions will be. Once the no-spend challenge is over, you can continue